



8 Sentences, Phrases and Clauses



The Sentence

You know that a *sentence* is a group of words that contains (a) a *subject*, (b) a *predicate*, and (c) makes complete sense by itself, i.e. it does not depend on any other word or group of words to do so.

(See Book 3, Chapter 10; Book 4, Chapter 9)

The predicate must contain a *finite verb*, which we shall refer to simply as *verb*.

- Sometimes the subject might not be mentioned—it is understood:

(a) *Please sit down.*

(The subject *You* is understood: Q: Who is to sit down? Ans: *You*)

- The predicate may consist of only a verb:

(b) *The dog is barking.*

Subject: *The dog*

Predicate: *is barking*

Now look at the following sentences:

(c) *The man was carrying a bag full of money.*

(d) *The wedding will be held at sunset.*

(e) *The boys were running to the playing field.*

Each of the above group of words contains a subject and a predicate:

(c) *The **man*** (subject)

| *was carrying a bag full of money.* (predicate)

(d) *The **wedding*** (subject)

| *will be held at sunset.* (predicate)

(e) *The **boys*** (subject)

| *were running to the playing field.* (predicate)

Also, each makes complete sense by itself. So, all three are *sentences*.



Note that in the above examples:

- (i) the subjects are—*man, wedding, boys*;
- (ii) the verbs are—*was carrying, will be held, were running*.



The Phrase

Now look at the sentences again. They contain smaller groups or clusters of words, none of which contains a subject and a predicate:

- (c) ... *full of money*
- (d) ... *at sunset*
- (e) ... *the playing field*

Moreover, none of these groups of words makes complete sense by itself; each depends on other groups of words to do so. Such a group of words is known as a *phrase*.

A **phrase** is a group of words which does not contain a subject and a verb, and does not make complete sense by itself.



The Clause

- (f) *The man was carrying a bag.*
- (g) *The bag was full of money.*

In (f) there is a subject (*man*) and a predicate (*was carrying a bag*).

In (g) there is a subject (*bag*) and a predicate (*was full of money*).

Moreover, each makes complete sense by itself. So, each is a sentence.

If we now join these two sentences together with a conjunction, we get:

- (h) *The man was carrying a bag and the bag was full of money.*

Since the two sentences have become parts of a larger sentence, we do not call them *sentences* any longer. We call them *clauses*.

A **clause** is a group of words which contains a subject and a predicate and is *part* of a sentence.

However, it is clear from the examples given that a sentence may contain *only one* clause or *more than one* clause:

- (i) *Birds were flying in the sky.*
- (j) *The fishing boats will return when the sun sets.*
- (k) *As soon as vacation starts, we shall go on an excursion.*

In (i), there is only one clause.

In (j), there are two clauses:

- (i) *The fishing boats will return*
- (ii) *when the sun sets*

In (k), there are two clauses:

- (i) *As soon as vacation starts*
- (ii) *we shall go on an excursion*



Phrases and Clauses

- (l) *The king sat on a golden throne.*
- (m) *The king sat on a throne of gold.*
- (n) *The king sat on a throne which was made of gold.*

In (l), *golden* is an adjective qualifying the noun *throne*.

In (m), *of gold*, which does not contain a subject and a predicate, is an adjective phrase that qualifies the noun *throne*.

In (n), *which was made of gold* consists of a subject (*which*) and a predicate (*was made of gold*), and is, therefore, a clause. It is an adjective clause which qualifies the noun *throne*.



Here are some more examples:

- (o) *Hari reached the station late.*
- (p) *Hari could not reach the station in time and missed the train.*
- (q) *Hari reached the station when the train had already left.*

In (o), *late* is an *adverb* that qualifies the verb *reached*.

In (p), *in time* is an *adverb phrase* that qualifies the verb *could (not) reach*.

In (q), *when the train had already left*, which contains a subject (*the train*) and a predicate (*had already left*), is an *adverb clause* which qualifies the verb *reached*.

Now, look at the following sentences:

(r) The smiling face of the girl filled me with happiness.

(s) The girl with a smile on her face is my sister.

(t) The girl, who is smiling, is my sister.

(u) When the girl smiles, she looks beautiful.

In (r), smiling is an adjective that qualifies the noun face.

In (s), with a smile on her face, which does not contain a subject and a predicate, is an adjective phrase which qualifies the noun girl.

In (t), who is smiling, which contains a subject (who) and a predicate (is smiling) is an adjective clause which qualifies the noun girl.

In (u), there are two clauses, joined together by the conjunction when:

(i) the girl (subject) + smiles (predicate)

(ii) she (subject) + looks beautiful (predicate)

Say which of the underlined groups of words are *phrases* and which *clauses*:

1. A man, who was walking through the forest, heard the roar of the tiger.
2. The flowers, all fresh and beautiful, will soon fade.
3. My brother, a good footballer, will play for the school team next year.
4. The travellers, who were hungry and thirsty, were looking for a hotel.
5. Do not believe all that you hear.
6. Spring came but gave the Giant's garden no flowers.
7. The scholar was sitting, all by himself, in the library full of books.
8. In her new clothes, the girl looked as pretty as a doll.
9. Bill, looking sad and upset, said that he had lost all the tickets for the Test Match.
10. During the vacation, now only a month away, we shall go to an adventure camp.
11. The tea, too sweet and too hot, was not fit for drinking.
12. In ancient times, a winner at the Olympic Games, was given a wreath of laurel leaves.
13. Do you know the actor who played the role of Hamlet?
14. No train, however fast, can travel this distance in an hour.
15. When the men fell asleep, the monster came out of the lake.

